

Art as Cultural System & AI Prompting

1. Art's Ineffable Quality

"Art, Clifford Geertz once remarked, *is notoriously hard to talk about.*" ¹

Geertz notes that many artists feel their work "speaks for itself," meaning its meaning often seems self-evident or mystical. In AI prompting, this means we rely on evocative descriptors (moods, styles, emotions) because literal definitions fall short. Prompting becomes a way to hint at ineffable qualities rather than pin them down.

- Prompt example: *"misty forest at dawn, ethereal mood"* – focusing on atmosphere and feeling rather than explicit content.

2. Embedding Art in Culture



Street art in Beijing, reflecting local style and symbols. Geertz argues that placing art within its social and cultural web is essential. "The chief problem presented by... aesthetic force... is how to place it within the other modes of social activity... [and] giving art objects a cultural significance, is always a local matter." ²

In prompts, we also encode cultural context (symbols, historical style, local motifs) to shape meaning.

- We capture local meaning by referencing shared symbols or periods. For example, a prompt like *"samurai warrior in Edo-period painting style"* invokes specific cultural codes and values.

3. The Role of Beauty and Style



A sunset silhouette – beauty's subtle impact. Geertz suggests society might not collapse without formal elegance, yet losing “elegance of line and harmonies of color” dulls our sense of wonder ³. In prompting, specifying aesthetic qualities (lighting, color harmony, composition) acknowledges beauty's power. Even if functionally optional, aesthetic detail influences how meaning is perceived.

- Prompt example: “*surreal cosmic landscape, vibrant colors, masterpiece quality*” – deliberately invoking beauty and style to enhance impact.

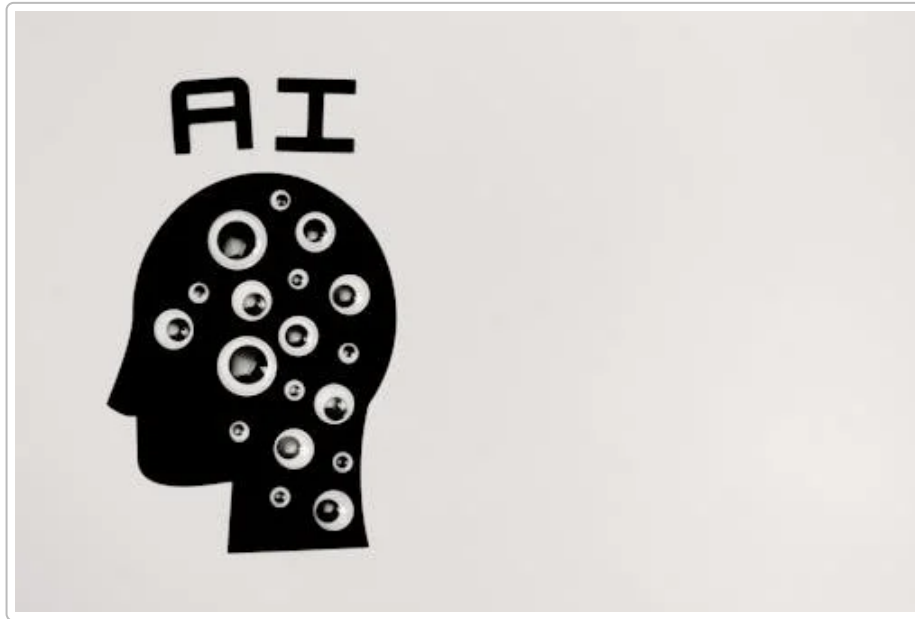
4. Art and Everyday Values



Interconnected network symbolizing how art and life entwine. Geertz observes that a people's feeling for life appears not only in art but in religion, morality, science, politics, commerce, technology, law and daily life ⁴. In AI art, prompts often reflect these broader values and beliefs. The images generated carry not just form but the community's mood and ethos embedded in the prompt.

- Prompt example: *"vibrant street festival at sunset, joyous crowd, folk-art style"* – combining everyday cultural activities, values, and artistic form.

5. Beyond Formalism: Context is Key



Abstract "AI" head – suggesting perception and context. Geertz warns against isolating form from meaning: "they head us off precisely in the wrong direction—toward an isolation of the meaning-form aspects... from the practical contexts that give them life" ⁵. Likewise, prompts that specify only style (e.g. "Baroque portrait style") without context risk shallow results. Richer outputs emerge when prompts add narrative or cultural content.

- Prompt example: *"Renaissance-style portrait of a futuristic AI robot, exploring identity"* – merges formal style with a narrative context to deepen meaning.

6. Talking About Art (and Prompts)

"Something meaningful to us cannot be left just to sit there bathed in pure significance; we describe, analyze, compare, judge, classify..." ⁶

Geertz notes that even though art seems to "speak for itself," people inevitably discuss and interpret it. Likewise, using and refining prompts is part of a broader discourse – a symbolic action. We constantly talk about and tweak prompts (and their outputs) to negotiate meaning.

- Prompt example: *"ancient temple ceremony at twilight, meditative mood"* – reflecting how we verbalize and share visions of meaningful scenes.

Sources: Key statements from Clifford Geertz, *"Art as a Cultural System"* ¹ ² ³ ⁴ ⁵ ⁶, annotated in light of AI prompting and aesthetic practice.

¹ ² ⁵ Art and "Thick Description," Part One | Art History Unstuffed

<https://arthistoryunstuffed.com/art-and-thick-description-part-one/>

³ d2r72yk5wmppdj.cloudfront.net

https://d2r72yk5wmppdj.cloudfront.net/m/52a931e10cbd43d0/DDM_III_Book_final.pdf

⁴ ⁶ Geertz, Art As Cultural System | PDF | Quran | Islam

<https://www.scribd.com/document/81506807/Geertz-Art-as-Cultural-System>